Do Pakistanis Hold Militant Groups in Low Regard?*

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Abstract

Blair et al. (2013) conclude from endorsement experiments that Pakistanis hold militant groups in "low regard." I reanalyze their survey and find that the average endorsement effect is small because reactions offset, not because respondents do not react. Each respondent answers four policy questions, and random assignment makes the control arm's joint distribution of the four answers the counterfactual for the endorsed arm. Under endorsement, answers to five of six policy pairs become more closely related, and respondents whose answers average the midpoint of the scale move away from it in both directions: that share falls by 3.8 percentage points. Endorsed arms simulated from control respondents show that opposition alone, tuned to reproduce the average effect, leaves the midpoint share unchanged. The measurement model developed for endorsement experiments (Bullock et al., 2011) implies a 43% probability of a positive latent reaction (95% credible interval 32%–53%), but it treats a respondent's reactions as independent across questions, which these patterns contradict. More generally, an average treatment effect does not identify the proportion holding favorable attitudes. Alternative behavioral assumptions yield different implied supporter proportions. The observed response marginals bound the fraction of responses increased by endorsement between 1% and 58%.

1 Introduction

Do Pakistanis hold militant groups in low regard? Blair et al. (2013) use endorsement experiments to measure affect toward four militant groups. They find small negative average effects on stated policy support and interpret them as weakly negative average affect. That interpretation leaves a different question open: how widely are favorable or unfavorable attitudes held?

The small average effect reflects offsetting reactions, not indifference. Because each respondent answers four policy questions, the control arm supplies the counterfactual for how a respondent's answers move together, not only for each answer separately. Under endorsement, answers to five of the six policy pairs become more closely related, which reactions carried across questions produce and independent noise does not. Respondents whose four answers average the midpoint of the scale become 3.8 percentage points rarer, with gains on both sides. Endorsed arms simulated from the control respondents show that opposition alone, at each of three intensities that reproduce the average effect, leaves that share unchanged (Section 5). The argument assumes that how a respondent reacts is unrelated to where their answers would otherwise sit.

*`https://github.com/finite-sample/endorsement`.

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The measurement model of Bullock et al. (2011) gives a 43% probability of a positive latent reaction to an endorsement, averaged equally across the four groups (95% credible interval 32%–53%), with mean reactions no larger than 0.08 ideal-point standard deviations and larger estimated dispersion. That model treats each reaction as independent across a respondent's questions, and the within-respondent patterns contradict it. The data show that substantial favorable and unfavorable reactions coexist; they do not pin down how many respondents react favorably.

The distinction between an average and a prevalence is general. An average treatment effect (ATE) combines the frequency and size of positive and negative effects. Its sign alone cannot separate them. Under behavioral assumptions linking favorable attitudes to positive effects, the same ATE can imply different supporter proportions. Some such assumptions are contradicted by the observed response distribution. Others produce implications for quantities that should not be equated: an unaffected fraction, a probability of positive latent affect, and a fraction of observed responses increased by an endorsement.

2 Endorsement Experiments

Endorsement experiments randomize whether a policy question includes an endorsement by an actor of interest. Respondents in the control condition evaluate the policy alone; those in the treatment condition evaluate the policy with the endorsement. With valid assignment and observation, the difference identifies an effect of the cue on stated policy support.

Interpreting that effect as affect toward the endorser requires more. Respondents must understand the endorsement, and its effect must operate through their attitudes toward the group rather than through other information the cue conveys. Even then, the size of a response change can depend on baseline policy preferences and the response scale. The design has been used to study militant groups in Pakistan and combatants in Afghanistan (Bullock et al., 2011; Blair et al., 2013; Lyall et al., 2013; Blair et al., 2014).

A negative ATE can reflect many small negative reactions, a few large ones, or positive and negative reactions that nearly cancel. It therefore does not identify the proportion with either sign of effect. Nor does the sign of an effect, without a measurement assumption, classify a respondent as a supporter or opponent.

3 The Experiment and Data

Blair et al. (2013) surveyed 6,000 adults in Pakistan's four main provinces in 2009. Their experiment covered Kashmiri tanzeems, the Afghan Taliban, al-Qa'ida, and sectarian tanzeems. Respondents evaluated polio vaccination, Frontier Crimes Regulation reform, the Durand Line, and curriculum standardization on a five-point intensity scale. I rescale responses to $[0, 1]$; a mean on this scale is not a percentage of respondents supporting a policy.

I use the analysis file supplied with the `endorse` R package (Shiraito and Imai, 2022). It contains 5,212 respondents with one observed answer per policy, yielding 10,619 control responses and 10,229 endorsed responses. The pooled control mean is 0.736, the treatment mean is 0.723, and

their difference is −0.013 (respondent-clustered SE 0.0052). These are response-weighted means across the available policy items and endorsers.

The analysis is unweighted. Blair et al. use population and policy weights; their survey oversampled Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. Their unconditional Table 1 has 5,358 respondents and a control mean of 0.796. Differences from the present estimates can reflect sample selection and policy weighting as well as population weighting. The model-based probabilities below therefore describe the fitted analysis sample, not nationally representative prevalence.

The package sample also retains assignment patterns excluded by the original replication code: 35 respondents have control and endorsed items across policies, and 94 receive the same endorser on multiple policies. Excluding these 129 respondents changes the pooled ATE from −0.01283 to −0.01272. This diagnostic leaves the sign and rounded magnitude intact. The Bayesian models retain the package sample; their sensitivity to these exclusions has not been estimated.

4 Model-Based Positive Latent Reactions

The measurement model of Bullock et al. (2011) relates ordinal policy responses to latent policy preferences and endorsement reactions. Respondent i has a latent position x_i. For question j endorsed by group k, the model adds a reaction s_{ijk} and maps the resulting position to an observed category through question-specific loadings and cutpoints. In the baseline specification,

$$s_{ijk} \sim \mathcal{N}(\lambda_k, \omega_k^2), \qquad P(s_{ijk} > 0) = \Phi(\lambda_k/\omega_k). \tag{1}$$

The mean and variance of the reaction distribution are common across policies. The reaction itself is question-specific; the specification does not assign each respondent a single fixed supporter status across all questions. The positive probability is invariant to the units of the latent scale.

A positive latent reaction need not move a response into a higher observed category. The model also includes response noise, so $P(s_{ijk} > 0)$ is distinct from the probability that the observed treatment response exceeds the control potential response. Its interpretation as favorable affect depends on the measurement model and the meaning of the endorsement cue. The model also draws each reaction independently across a respondent's questions; Section 5 shows that the data contradict this, so the estimates below describe the fitted model rather than a validated prevalence.

I fit the baseline model without covariates using `endorse`.[1] Table 1 reports posterior means and credible intervals. Averaged equally over groups, the probability of a positive latent reaction is 43% (95% credible interval 32%–53%). This is an average of four marginal probabilities, not the probability of favoring at least one group. The Afghan Taliban have the lowest estimate, 32%, and a wide interval, 2%–49%. Their posterior probability of a negative mean reaction is 0.98; the other groups' mean-reaction intervals include zero.

Other analyses of this survey also describe heterogeneity. Blair et al.'s middle-income treatment

[1] The fitting script uses three chains with starting values dispersed across negative, zero, and positive mean reactions. Each chain runs for 200,000 iterations, discards 20,000, and retains every 40th draw. The largest reported Gelman–Rubin statistic across the mean and variance parameters is 1.016, and the smallest effective sample size across mean reactions is 1355. The fits use the package's default priors.

Table 1: Positive latent reactions under the baseline measurement model

Endorser	$P(s > 0)$	95% CrI	Mean reaction (ideal-point SDs)	Reaction SD (ideal-point SDs)
Kashmiri tanzeems	45%	[25%, 58%]	−0.03	0.25
Afghan Taliban	32%	[2%, 49%]	−0.08	0.20
Al-Qaeda	47%	[40%, 54%]	−0.03	0.49
Sectarian tanzeems	49%	[38%, 57%]	−0.01	0.36
Average	43%	[32%, 53%]	−0.04	0.32

Unweighted analysis sample, $n = 5,212$. CrI denotes a 95% credible interval. Mean reaction and reaction SD are posterior means in ideal-point SD units. The average row weights the four endorsers equally.

effects range from −0.006 to 0.001 across specifications, while low-income effects range from −0.026 to −0.019 on the rescaled outcome. Bullock et al. estimate geographic variation in latent affect, with positive estimates in parts of Punjab and negative estimates in Balochistan and NWFP.

Adding gender, rurality, education, and income covariates raises the average positive probability to 44%; a model with division-level means raises it to 49% (Table 2). The increase is in the average, not every group-specific estimate. The Afghan Taliban estimate rises to 45% under the hierarchical specification. The covariate and hierarchical summaries average over the sample's covariates and division frequencies, respectively.

Table 2: Positive latent reactions across measurement-model specifications

Endorser	Baseline	Covariates	Hierarchical
Kashmiri tanzeems	45% [25%, 58%]	45% [34%, 54%]	49% [44%, 55%]
Afghan Taliban	32% [2%, 49%]	39% [27%, 48%]	45% [40%, 51%]
Al-Qaeda	47% [40%, 54%]	46% [40%, 52%]	49% [44%, 54%]
Sectarian tanzeems	49% [38%, 57%]	48% [39%, 56%]	51% [46%, 56%]
Average	43% [32%, 53%]	44% [38%, 51%]	49% [44%, 53%]

Posterior means with 95% credible intervals in brackets. All specifications use the unweighted package sample. Baseline reactions have common group means; covariate means depend on individual characteristics; hierarchical means vary by division. The average row weights endorsers equally.

5 Within-Respondent Patterns

Each respondent answers all four policy questions. Endorsed respondents receive a different group on each question; control respondents receive none. Random assignment therefore gives the control arm's joint distribution of the four answers as the counterfactual for the endorsed arm. Two features of that joint distribution bear on the measurement model: how a respondent's answers move together across policies, and the distribution of each respondent's mean answer. Neither requires a model. The 35 respondents with both control and endorsed items are excluded from this section; intervals are percentile bootstrap intervals over respondents.

In the measurement model, reactions are independent across questions for the same respondent,

so the correlation between any two policy answers is the same with and without an endorsement, apart from the effect of the mean shift on the discrete scale. Table 3 shows that the correlations change, and not in one direction. The two policies whose answers are most strongly related in the control arm, Frontier Crimes Regulation reform and the Durand Line, become less related under endorsement: the correlation falls from 0.66 to 0.54 (−0.12, 95% interval [−0.16, −0.07]). Every other pair becomes more related, by 0.07 to 0.18, with every interval excluding zero. A reaction that each respondent carries across all four endorsements raises every pairwise correlation; a cue that also loosens the link between an answer and the respondent's policy position lowers the correlation for the pair most tightly linked to that position. The pattern is consistent with both operating together. It is not consistent with reactions that are independent across questions, and it is not consistent with reactions that enter each question in proportion to that question's loading on the latent position, which would raise the FCR–Durand correlation most.

Table 3: Correlations between policy answers, by arm

Policy pair	Control	Endorsed	Difference	95% interval
Polio – FCR	0.08	0.16	+0.08	[+0.02, +0.14]
Polio – Durand	0.02	0.11	+0.09	[+0.03, +0.14]
Polio – Curriculum	0.16	0.23	+0.07	[+0.02, +0.13]
FCR – Durand	0.66	0.54	−0.12	[−0.16, −0.07]
FCR – Curriculum	0.13	0.31	+0.18	[+0.13, +0.24]
Durand – Curriculum	0.14	0.25	+0.11	[+0.06, +0.17]

Pearson correlations between the rescaled answers to two policies, across respondents within each arm. Intervals are 95% percentile bootstrap intervals for the difference, resampling respondents within arms. Respondents with both control and endorsed items are excluded.

Table 4 compares the distribution of each respondent's mean answer across the four policies. Indifference predicts no change. In the control arm, 10.8% of respondents have answers that average exactly the midpoint of the scale; under endorsement 7.0% do, a change of −3.8 [−5.4, −2.3] percentage points. Mass appears on both sides of the midpoint: +2.1 [+1.0, +3.1] points one step below and +2.7 [+1.1, +4.3] points one step above, while the bin two steps above is unchanged (+0.1 [−1.7, +1.8]). The gain one step above the midpoint cannot have come from above, so some respondents at the midpoint moved up. The rest of the distribution drifts down: the lower tail gains +1.7 [+0.7, +2.7] points and the upper bins lose a little, although those changes are not distinguishable from zero. The share of respondents at the top of the scale on all four policies is 16.4% in the control arm and changes by −0.3 [−2.1, +1.8] points under endorsement. Favorable reactions among the 31.1% of respondents averaging 0.875 or higher are largely invisible by construction; unfavorable reactions anywhere are not.

The most direct alternative to offsetting reactions is a minority that reacts strongly against the endorser while everyone else is unmoved. That alternative also produces a small average effect and greater dispersion. To see whether it can produce the midpoint pattern, Table 5 builds endorsed arms from the control respondents themselves. In each simulated arm, a reacting respondent moves each of their four answers one step in their direction with a fixed probability, and the share of opponents is chosen so the expected average effect equals the observed one. Opposition alone,

Table 4: Distribution of each respondent's mean answer, by arm

Mean answer	Control	Endorsed	Difference (pp)	95% interval
≤ 0.375	2.9%	4.6%	+1.7	[+0.7, +2.7]
0.4375	2.9%	4.9%	+2.1	[+1.0, +3.1]
0.5	10.8%	7.0%	−3.8	[−5.4, −2.3]
0.5625	7.7%	10.4%	+2.7	[+1.1, +4.3]
0.625	12.3%	12.4%	+0.1	[−1.7, +1.8]
0.6875–0.8125	32.4%	30.7%	−1.7	[−4.2, +0.9]
0.875–0.9375	14.6%	13.7%	−0.9	[−2.8, +0.9]
1	16.4%	16.2%	−0.3	[−2.1, +1.8]

Mean of a respondent's four rescaled answers, which takes values in sixteenths. Sparse bins are pooled. Differences are in percentage points of respondents; intervals are 95% percentile bootstrap intervals, resampling respondents within arms.

held by 5% to 22% of respondents depending on how many answers move, leaves the midpoint share where it was (changes of +0.0 to +0.1 points). Respondents leaving the midpoint downward are replaced by respondents arriving from above. In 97.5% of simulated samples of the observed size, opposition alone lowers the midpoint share by less than 1.8 points; the observed change is −3.8 [−5.4, −2.3]. Adding a favorable group empties the midpoint: with 30% favorable and 29% opposed, the change is −2.0 points. No simulated world reproduces the observed gain one step above the midpoint (at most +0.7 points on average, against +2.7 [+1.1, +4.3] observed).

Table 5: Observed and simulated changes under endorsement

Endorsed arm	Oppose	Favor	Answers moved	Spread (×100)	Midpoint (pp)	One below (pp)	One above (pp)
Observed				+0.41 [+0.19, +0.63]	−3.8 [−5.4, −2.3]	+2.1 [+1.0, +3.1]	+2.7 [+1.1, +4.3]
Opposition only	22%	0%	25%	+0.10 [−0.11, +0.29]	+0.0 [−1.6, +1.7]	+1.0 [+0.1, +2.0]	+0.6 [−0.9, +2.0]
Opposition only	11%	0%	50%	+0.15 [−0.08, +0.35]	+0.1 [−1.6, +1.8]	+0.8 [−0.1, +1.8]	+0.4 [−1.0, +1.9]
Opposition only	5%	0%	100%	+0.26 [+0.05, +0.48]	+0.0 [−1.8, +1.9]	+0.5 [−0.4, +1.5]	+0.2 [−1.2, +1.8]
Both directions	17%	10%	50%	+0.21 [+0.01, +0.42]	−0.6 [−2.3, +1.1]	+1.2 [+0.2, +2.1]	+0.5 [−0.8, +1.9]
Both directions	23%	20%	50%	+0.28 [+0.07, +0.47]	−1.3 [−3.0, +0.3]	+1.4 [+0.5, +2.5]	+0.6 [−0.9, +2.1]
Both directions	29%	30%	50%	+0.35 [+0.13, +0.57]	−2.0 [−3.6, −0.4]	+1.7 [+0.7, +2.7]	+0.7 [−0.9, +2.3]

Changes from the control arm. The first row is the observed endorsed arm, with 95% percentile bootstrap intervals resampling respondents within arms. Other rows are simulated endorsed arms built by resampling control respondents to the size of the endorsed arm. A reacting respondent moves each answer one step (0.25) down if opposed or up if favorable, with the probability shown as answers moved, truncated at the ends of the scale. The opposed share is set so the expected average effect equals the observed one. Simulated rows report the mean and the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles over 500 simulated samples. Spread is the variance of a respondent's mean answer. Midpoint is the share of respondents whose answers average 0.5; one below and one above are the shares averaging 0.4375 and 0.5625.

This comparison holds the counterfactual fixed at the observed control arm and varies only the direction of reactions. It assumes that whether and how a respondent reacts is unrelated to where their answers would otherwise sit. Without that assumption the marginal distributions alone guarantee only that some respondents moved down: a sharp lower bound on the share whose mean answer fell is 3.8%, while the corresponding bound for a rise is 0.2%, because a reaction that lowers only the answers of respondents just above the midpoint could refill it. The comparison also does not exclude every mechanism that moves answers in both directions. An endorsement could, for

example, push respondents off the middle of the scale toward their own policy views without any of them reacting to the group; that mechanism also empties the midpoint. What the comparison excludes is the reading under which the small average effect comes from a group that reacts in one direction while the rest do not react at all.

These patterns do not identify a proportion of favorable reactions. They establish that endorsements produce reactions that respondents carry across questions, that those reactions are large relative to the average effect, and that where movement in both directions is observable it occurs in both directions. The small average effect reflects opposing reactions that offset, not an absence of reactions.

6 Behavioral Assumptions and Supporter Proportions

The measurement model estimates a latent distribution under parametric assumptions. A simpler decomposition shows why the ATE alone cannot identify a supporter proportion. Suppose a proportion p holds favorable attitudes and the remainder holds unfavorable attitudes. Let δ^+ and δ^- be their average effects on the observed response. Then

$$\beta = p\delta^+ + (1-p)\delta^-. \tag{2}$$

Interpreting the two classes as supporters and opponents requires behavioral assumptions, such as $\delta^+ > 0$ and $\delta^- < 0$. One observed mean effect cannot determine the three unknowns. This is a partial-identification problem (Manski, 1990). The control mean α supplies information about baseline responses, but does not resolve the decomposition without restrictions on how baseline preferences relate to attitudes and effects.

6.1 Binary Switching and Baseline Information

Suppose every supporter ends at 1 and every opponent at 0 under treatment. Then the treatment mean directly identifies p:

$$p = E[Y(1)] = \alpha + \beta. \tag{3}$$

This endpoint restriction identifies p without separately identifying both class-specific baseline means. Applied to the pooled data it gives 72.3%. But the restriction also predicts treatment variance $p(1-p)$ and excludes all interior responses. The observed interior categories contradict this model.

The baseline still matters. Reporting α and β reveals both treatment and control means, whereas reporting only β discards information about the scale's available room for movement. The control mean of 0.736 is a mean intensity, not a supporter fraction. For comparison, 70.7% of control responses occupy the top two categories.

Partial awareness requires another assumption. If a fraction q has an opinion and follows binary

switching, while the rest is unaffected with baseline mean a_U, then

$$p_{\text{aware}} = \frac{\alpha + \beta - (1-q)a_U}{q}. \tag{4}$$

The expression $\alpha + \beta/q$ follows only if the unaffected subgroup has baseline mean α. With $q = 0.7$ as an illustrative assumption, allowing feasible subgroup means gives a range from 60% to 100%, rather than a unique estimate near the full-sample treatment mean. This calculation remains conditional on binary switching among opinion-holders.

6.2 Alternative Moment Restrictions

To illustrate sensitivity to assumptions, I hold the pooled ATE fixed and vary the restrictions on endorsement effects.

Symmetric class-average effects. If $\delta^+ = d$ and $\delta^- = -d$, then

$$p = \frac{\beta}{2d} + \frac{1}{2}, \qquad |\beta| \leq d. \tag{5}$$

Using the pooled ATE, $d = 0.05$ implies 37%, whereas $d = 0.02$ implies 18%. These choices constrain class-average effects; they do not require every individual to move by a noninteger number of response categories. Neither value of d is identified by the pooled ATE and baseline alone.

Extreme opponent reactions. If opponents move from 1 to 0 and everyone else is unaffected, then $\beta = -(1-p)$, so $p = 1 + \beta$, or 99%. Here p is the unaffected fraction. Calling it a supporter fraction requires an additional classification assumption; the calculation supplies no positive reactions. The restriction also implies $\beta \leq 0$ and specific changes in the endpoint masses.

A continuous normal approximation. If one approximates individual effects by $\delta_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\beta, \sigma^2)$, then $P(\delta_i > 0) = \Phi(\beta/\sigma)$. Setting $\sigma = 0.05$ gives 40%. An exact normal distribution is incompatible with differences on a bounded five-point scale. This calculation is a continuous approximation, not a fitted ordinal model. It differs from Equation (1), where normality applies to a latent reaction rather than an observed response difference.

7 Observed Distributions, Bounds, and Sensitivity

7.1 Endpoint Restrictions and Response Variation

Table 6 applies the moment calculations separately by endorser. Each ATE compares the group's pooled endorsed responses with the pooled control responses. The Afghan Taliban have the most negative difference and the lowest implied fraction under each formula. Each formula is an increasing function of the ATE, so the group ordering is the same under all of them.

Binary switching predicts a pooled treatment SD of 0.45, compared with the observed 0.29. Across policy–endorser cells, the average observed variance divided by the average predicted variance is 0.42 (Table 7). Interior responses directly violate the endpoint restriction; the variance comparison summarizes the discrepancy. Given a treatment mean m and variance v, the diagnostic is $v/[m(1-m)]$.

Table 6: Moment-based implications by endorser

Endorser	ATE	Binary	Symmetric	Normal	Extreme
Kashmiri tanzeems	−0.0113	72.5%	38.7%	41.1%	98.9%
Afghan Taliban	−0.0174	71.8%	32.6%	36.4%	98.3%
Al-Qaeda	−0.0142	72.2%	35.8%	38.8%	98.6%
Sectarian tanzeems	−0.0085	72.7%	41.5%	43.3%	99.2%

ATEs are differences on the 0–1 response scale in the unweighted sample. Binary denotes the endpoint model; symmetric uses $d = 0.05$; normal uses the continuous approximation with $\sigma = 0.05$; extreme denotes the unaffected fraction under maximal opponent reactions.

Table 7: Observed variance versus the binary-switching prediction

Policy	Endorser	Var(T) Obs	Var(T) Pred	Ratio
Polio	Kashmiri tanzeems	0.057	0.151	0.38
Polio	Afghan Taliban	0.064	0.159	0.40
Polio	Al-Qaeda	0.060	0.144	0.41
Polio	Sectarian tanzeems	0.061	0.154	0.40
FCR	Kashmiri tanzeems	0.074	0.215	0.35
FCR	Afghan Taliban	0.085	0.225	0.38
FCR	Al-Qaeda	0.088	0.220	0.40
FCR	Sectarian tanzeems	0.081	0.214	0.38
Durand	Kashmiri tanzeems	0.101	0.223	0.45
Durand	Afghan Taliban	0.094	0.219	0.43
Durand	Al-Qaeda	0.106	0.225	0.47
Durand	Sectarian tanzeems	0.099	0.216	0.46
Curriculum	Kashmiri tanzeems	0.085	0.196	0.43
Curriculum	Afghan Taliban	0.090	0.194	0.47
Curriculum	Al-Qaeda	0.085	0.196	0.43
Curriculum	Sectarian tanzeems	0.089	0.199	0.45
Average		0.082	0.197	0.42

Treatment responses are rescaled to 0–1. Predicted variance is $m(1-m)$ for each cell's treatment mean m; observed variance uses the sample variance. The final ratio divides the two column averages. Interior response categories contradict the endpoint model.

7.2 Ceiling Effects on the Discrete Scale

The response ceiling can attenuate upward movement. In the control group, 42% of responses are at 1. A respondent at that endpoint cannot report greater policy support, although a respondent with an unfavorable reaction can move down. This is a measurement constraint, not bias in an ATE defined on the observed response scale.

For an illustration, suppose supporters and opponents share the observed control distribution, and each moves up or down by the same number of categories, subject to the endpoints. Let $\bar{\delta}^+$ and $\bar{\delta}^-$ denote the resulting average shifts. Solving Equation (2) gives 59% for a one-category shift, 66% for two, and 70% for three (Table 8). The baseline distribution within attitude classes is unobserved; compatibility of the resulting treatment distribution with the data would require a separate check. The calculations show how truncation can produce a negative mean despite a majority assigned to the favorable class.

Table 8: Fixed category shifts with truncation at the scale endpoints

Shift	Eff. δ^+	Eff. δ^-	Ceiling Loss	Implied p
1 category	0.145	-0.236	0.105	58.6%
2 categories	0.218	-0.454	0.282	65.6%
3 categories	0.251	-0.631	0.499	70.1%

Both attitude classes are assigned the pooled control response distribution. Effects and ceiling loss are in 0–1 scale units; ceiling loss is the nominal upward shift minus its truncated average. Implied p matches the pooled ATE under each restriction.

7.3 Comparing the Illustrations

Table 9 collects the moment implications. The range from 18% to 99% demonstrates how different restrictions and definitions can produce different answers from the same means. It is not a confidence interval, an identification region, or evidence that the data fit every restriction.

Table 9: Illustrative implications of the pooled outcome means

Restriction	Assumption	Implied fraction
Extreme opponent reaction	$\delta^- = -1$, $\delta^+ = 0$	98.7%
Binary switching	All supporters $\to 1$, opponents $\to 0$	72.3%
5-point scale, 2-step shift	Shift ± 2 categories, truncated	65.6%
5-point scale, 1-step shift	Shift ± 1 category, truncated	58.6%
Normal heterogeneity ($\sigma = 0.05$)	$\delta_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\beta, 0.05^2)$	39.9%
Symmetric effects ($d = 0.05$)	$\delta^+ = +0.05$, $\delta^- = -0.05$	37.2%
Symmetric effects ($d = 0.02$)	$\delta^+ = +0.02$, $\delta^- = -0.02$	17.9%

All rows use the unweighted pooled ATE -0.013 and, where required, control mean 0.736. Fractions refer to the class defined by each restriction. Binary switching is contradicted by the observed interior categories. The normal row is a continuous approximation; the extreme row is an unaffected fraction. No sampling intervals are shown.

Figure 1 varies the ATE while holding each restriction fixed. Lines stop where the implied fraction would leave $[0, 1]$. For example, symmetric effects with magnitude d require $|\beta| \leq d$;

positive ATEs are incompatible with the extreme-opponent restriction.

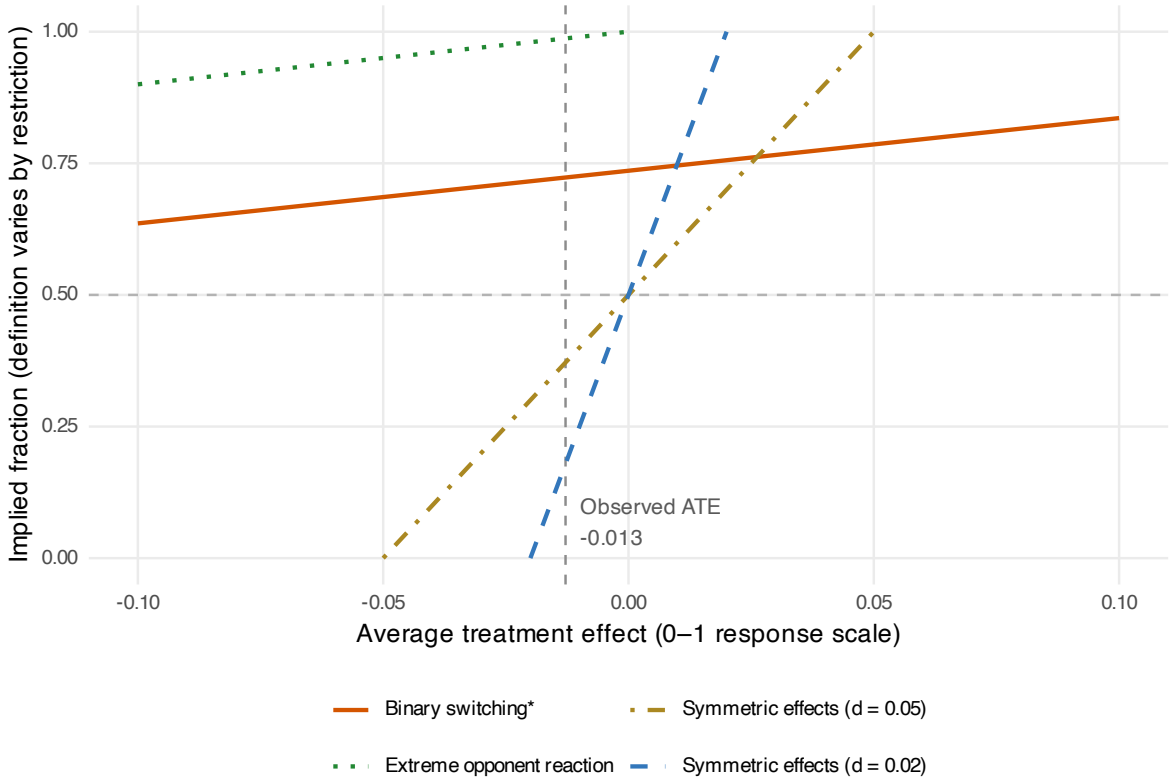


Figure 1: Sensitivity of moment implications to the ATE on the 0–1 scale. The baseline mean for binary switching is held at 0.736. Curves omit infeasible probabilities; they do not flatten at zero or one. The vertical line marks the unweighted pooled ATE, and the horizontal line marks one half. The asterisk identifies the contradicted endpoint restriction. Curves describe deterministic formulas, not sampling uncertainty.

7.4 Bounds on Observed Response Increases

A different calculation bounds observed response changes without specifying a latent reaction distribution. Under valid randomization, observation, and consistency assumptions, the experiment identifies treatment and control marginal outcome distributions, but not their joint distribution. Allowing every coupling of the estimated pooled marginals gives bounds of 1% to 58% on the fraction of person–policy responses for which $Y(1) > Y(0)$ (Table 10). These are plug-in bounds conditional on the empirical marginals, not confidence limits. Pooling also discards policy-specific restrictions on the joint distribution.

Independent random pairing yields a higher treatment response 34% of the time, a lower one 37%, and a tie 29%. Independence is an additional assumption about the coupling, not a feature identified by the experiment. The bounds permit either a minority or a majority of observed responses to increase. They do not bound the fraction holding favorable attitudes or the latent probability in Section 4.

Table 10: Random pairing and bounds on observed response increases

Endorser	$P(T < C)$	$P(T = C)$	$P(T > C)$	Min. Positive	Max. Positive
Kashmiri tanzeems	37%	29%	34%	2%	58%
Afghan Taliban	38%	29%	34%	1%	58%
Al-Qaeda	37%	29%	34%	1%	58%
Sectarian tanzeems	36%	29%	35%	1%	58%
All groups	37%	29%	34%	1%	58%

T and C denote treatment and control responses on the five-point scale. The first three columns pair them independently; the last two optimize $P(T > C)$ over all couplings of the empirical pooled marginals. The unit is a person–policy response. Bounds omit sampling uncertainty and do not measure positive latent affect.

7.5 Comparison with Direct Polling

Pew's 2012 survey reports 14% favorable views of the Afghan Taliban, 45% unfavorable views, and 41% with no opinion (Pew Research Center, 2012). If stated opinions are classified correctly, assigning all nonrespondents to the favorable category gives an upper bound of 55%. That bound does not allow respondents who report unfavorable opinions to conceal favorable ones.

The corresponding Afghan Taliban estimate from the 2009 endorsement data is 32% (95% credible interval 2%–49%). It falls within the range obtained by varying the classification of Pew nonrespondents. But the surveys differ in year, sample composition, and measurement, and the latent probability is not the same response as direct favorability. Social desirability and fear may contribute to discrepancies; these data do not identify their contribution.

8 Discussion

Researchers should distinguish the average effect on an observed response, the fraction of responses with positive effects, and the prevalence of favorable attitudes. Random assignment identifies the first under the usual design assumptions. Marginal response distributions can bound the second. Estimating the third requires a model connecting responses to attitudes, and its credibility depends on that connection.

Reporting treatment and control distributions alongside the ATE makes such assumptions easier to assess. Endpoint restrictions can be checked against interior responses; ceiling constraints are visible in the baseline distribution. Model-based positive probabilities should be reported with credible intervals, the population over which they are averaged, and evidence about model fit and sensitivity to priors.

The within-respondent patterns in Section 5 are the first such check this paper applies, and the baseline measurement model does not pass it: the model implies unchanged correlations across policy answers, and the data show correlations that rise for most pairs and fall for one. A model in which a reaction shifts a respondent's answers directly, rather than through the latent position, is the natural alternative. Latent-class versions of that model, with opponents, unaffected respondents, and supporters, did not identify the favorable share in these data: the estimate depended on how the response ceiling was modelled, the sizes of favorable and unfavorable shifts could not

be separated, and simulated data with no supporters returned a positive share. The replication materials document these attempts. The present reanalysis also leaves open population adjustment, Bayesian sensitivity to the assignment exclusions, prior sensitivity, and posterior predictive fit of the baseline model. Endorsement credibility is another measurement question. If respondents disbelieve a cue or infer information beyond the endorser's identity, the mapping to attitudes can change; the direction of that change is not established by the ATE alone.

Three changes to the design would identify more. Randomizing whether the group is said to support or oppose the policy separates reactions to the group from a general push away from the middle of the scale: a respondent who favors the group should move in opposite directions under the two cues, and a respondent pushed toward their own view should not. An endorsement by a neutral or widely liked actor measures how much any cue disperses answers. Policies with intermediate baseline support, or a finer response scale, leave room for favorable reactions to appear; here 42% of control responses are already at the top. Asking the policy questions without an endorsement in an earlier wave would go further, by observing each respondent's own shift and so the sizes of favorable and unfavorable reactions separately. Repeated-measures designs in survey experiments have generally not altered treatment effects (Clifford et al., 2021), although consistency pressure across waves would need to be checked.

9 Conclusion

A small negative average endorsement effect does not mean respondents are indifferent to militant groups. In these data it is the net of reactions in both directions: answers to most policy pairs become more closely related under endorsement, and the middle of the scale empties in a way that opposition alone does not produce. How many respondents react favorably is not identified. The fitted measurement model puts the probability of a positive latent reaction at 43%, but under an assumption the data reject. Moving from an average response effect to a distribution of attitudes requires stating and defending the additional assumptions, and designs that flip the direction of the cue or observe each respondent's own shift would require fewer of them.

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